

Over three decades, I've had the privilege of working with incredible athletes, coaches, and organisations at many levels of sport. Through those

experiences, one truth has become very loud and clear — success in Strength and Conditioning (S&C) coaching rarely comes from one big breakthrough; instead, it comes from a collection of principles that guide how we think, lead, and respond to the challenges that come with this profession.

Here is why I'm putting together four pointers based on my observations over the years as a professional S&C coach:

The coach as the chameleon:

Becoming the most adaptable coach in the building without compromising self-respect and truth.

Know your role and manage expectations: Understanding how to operate within the system of sport, recognising your limitations and value. Being open to learning without much ego.

Regulate your inner A.P.E.:

Mastering attitude, preparation, and effort.

Conveying it all together:

Combining these principles to build successful coaches and programmes for the long-term process.

Strength coaching is not just about programming alone. It is about adaptability, leadership, and controlling the things that truly determine success.

Let's discuss each of the points above.

THE COACH AS THE CHAMELEON

S&C coaches must wear many hats. Depending on the time of the year or the state of affairs, they may serve as:

- ✦ Motivator
- ✦ Disciplinarian
- ✦ Problem solver
- ✦ Advisor
- ✦ Friend
- ✦ Mentor
- ✦ Confidant
- ✦ Philosopher

During a single training session, they may move through several of

these roles within minutes. Here, adaptability is the key.

Because of that reality, I often describe these coaches as chameleons — not in a negative connotation but from a positive angle, adapting to the environment. Many get the wrong end of the stick on adaptation and muddle it up through various means, spoiling their reputation.

In my opinion, the strength coach should strive to be the most adaptable coach in the building.

THE REALITY OF DAILY ADAPTATION

Programming and scheduling are foremost responsibilities in their profession. They spend hours designing training plans and organising facility schedules so athletes can train efficiently and safely.

But the reality is that plans change, often unexpectedly. For example, you may have planned and mapped out a perfect gym session for each player, and the coach walks in and says, "No lifting today. Instead, go for a run," since there is a shift in the skill session by a couple of hours, or there is no skill session at all.

Now the entire schedule must shift. Modify and adjust the programme accordingly and effectively. Complaining about the situation solves nothing. Great coaches adapt, adopt and move forward quickly. Being prepared for unexpected events is part of the job profile.

COACHING THE ATHLETE IN FRONT OF YOU

Adaptability also applies to the athletes we work with every day. Athletes bring more than their physical ability into the weight room or ground.

They also bring their emotions, stress, personal issues, fatigue, self-doubt, bad moods, etc. As a good and adaptable coach, one must understand the body language of each and every player and member of the support staff.

Being a slave driver to prove oneself to be a tough S&C coach on that particular day would be

counterproductive. Proving one's toughness and no-nonsense attitude can work at times, but many times it fails and causes trauma and injuries to the players and even oneself.

Adjusting the training system on that particular day, modifying the schedule, letting them be themselves during that session, or pulling a player aside for a fruitful conversation makes the athlete trust the system and helps them give their best in each session.

The responsibility should be to push the players to improve while ensuring their trust and maintaining a clear objective not to harm them in any way. Here, many S&C coaches tend to fail and lose players' trust by being a spy for the coaches or the management on players' weaknesses to gain brownie points. Maintaining confidentiality is critical for the players' trust. It's not about being famous and raking in money; it's all about work ethics and the philosophy of work.

SERVING THE PROGRAMME

S&C coaches operate within a team environment. Their motto is to serve the team to the best of their knowledge and efficiency in preparing the players physically and mentally for success.

Serving the programme does not imply surrendering professional standards. Clear communication, justifying the reasons behind the physical programme, maintaining discretion and upholding core values make a great strength coach.

Respect should be earned through consistency, knowledge, performance, low injury levels, deliverables, and the ability to lead. These are a few important pointers that should be adhered to.

The best S&C coaches are not just great programmers; they are adaptable to any sport, skill, environment, schedule, player and management need.

It's important to understand that success often depends on how quickly one can adapt to your environment. Because in strength coaching, the unexpected is not the exception — it is the profession.